

Bluff

YOUR WAY THROUGH

Cryptography

All about cracking codes and secret messages, "cryptography" has a glamorous Bond-like ring to it, though the actual science that goes into it is highly mathematical. That said, most of us wonder what exactly public key cryptography means.

SSL: Secure Socket Layer is a cryptographic protocol used in e-mails, IM and other data transfers over the Internet. SSL and its related protocol, TLS (Transport Layer Security), are grouped in the topmost (Application) layer of TCP/IP.

Public Key Cryptography: The most widely used type of cryptography, PKC uses a public key that is widely distributed, and a secret private key. The sender encrypts a message with the receiver's public key, which can only be decrypted using the receiver's private key. The keys are generated using algorithms like RSA.

RSA: A widely-used algorithm used in PKC. It uses two large prime numbers to generate public and private keys. The keys generated by RSA have been very resistant to attack.

Hash functions: These take a variable-length input and generate a fixed-length output. As used in cryptography, they are designed so that it's impossible to get the input data even by knowing the output and the function. Hash functions like MD5 and SHA-1 are used in digital certificates for verifying data identity and/or integrity.

Digital certificate: These are used in online transactions to verify identities. They are typically issued by a trusted third-party Certificate Authority and have information that can identify the owner.

Usage: RSA is a bit slow, though it's the best *public key cryptography* algorithm. But for foolproof security, use a *hash function* like MD5 in your *digital certificate*, and when you send the document to use enable *SSL* in your browser's security settings.

Wild Wild Web

Blood Money

A contract killer with a heart of gold gets a hit order. He alerts the victim and gives him a chance to save his life. The only catch—the would-be victim would have to pay up. Sounds like a movie script, right? Well, this was the proposal a 72-year-old pensioner in New Jersey got when he opened his inbox—the amount mentioned was \$8,000, with half to be paid immediately. He was also warned not to speak to anybody about this; his friends were likely to be involved in the plot and he would get his goose cooked.

Harry Whitworth promptly smelt a scam and immediately

called the cops. After ascertaining that he wasn't involved with the mob or other unsavoury characters, the Feds included his name as a part of the US-wide operation. The cops hope to catch the scum behind the scam, though they have not much leads. Knowing how these scams spread though, we will be watching our inboxes.

Listing Sin

Information about peep shows, brothels, and massage parlours has always proliferated through word of mouth, but with the Internet, this information is a few clicks away—if you know where to

look. A very good place is Craigslist—it's well-known, free, and anonymous. But Craigslist draws the attention of cops, especially if you list live sex shows near a church and a school. Now in the Windy City, a bored officer of the Chicago police was looking at listings when he came upon explicit ones that advertised live sex shows. You could, for \$240, watch couples having sex. Pay some more, and you could take part. And so, the coppers raided the house of ill fame and took the performers and the manager into custody. We're guessing the first thing the manager does when he gets out is sue Craigslist...

know—no refunds) for another iPod, which unfortunately, was out of stock. A neighbouring store said they had enough stock, so the duo legged it to that one. Once bitten, they wanted to have a look at the iPod before taking it home. Due to another store policy, they had to buy the iPod and then open the pack. The iPod bought, the teen excitedly opened the pack and..... found it filled with rocks. Again.

Fed up to the skin of the teeth, the Ritters demanded their money back. But once cash is in, it does not come out of the system. The staff suggested they pick up something else for \$350. The daughter, her heart set on a Video iPod, desolately collected knick-knacks totalling that amount, while mom stood aside swearing tort action.

Apple, as usual, declined comments while the store chain's PR department issued clarifications couched in homilies such as ensuring the customer's satisfaction and blah blah.

We are guessing a US-wide, possibly global, conspiracy headquartered from a certain city in Washington state to infiltrate iPod supply lines...



HOSTILE TERRITORY

Hate Thy Enemies

What's the *sine qua non* of social networking sites? Making friends, talking to new people, and so much more... But the operative word here is *friends*. You don't generally behave like a jerk; that people do at usual sites is beside the point. What if you're tired of keeping up an artificial façade of sweetness during those days of the month when you go around smashing furniture and snapping at everyone in sight?

Everybody feels like that at some point or the other, of course. So if you ache for some good ol' bile, do yourself and others a favour by heading over to Hatebook (www.hatebook.org) and vent that ire. It's therapeutic, as shrinks have repeatedly told us, and there is that thing about keeping friends close and enemies closer.

Hatebook, if you haven't already guessed, is a parody of Facebook. The look and feel is the same, except the colour scheme is a fiery red for Facebook's placid blue. After registering, you are welcomed with a "hello, sucker" message, which sets the tone of things to follow. Your profile is made up of fields like Music that sucks, Brands I hate, Movies that bother, Books I hate... you get the idea. People who visit you are Idiots, while you write Junk Mail to anybody and post on their Blackboard. You can add people you hate and bad-mouth them; the only limit is how wide your vocabulary is. In fact, being nice to people is frowned upon here; you have only enemies to add, though you could be friends with your enemy's enemy and join forces in pouring scorn on the poor blighter... We hate to admit